

# **Reflective Analysis of Decision-Making and Problem-Solving**

## **Introduction**

Decision making and problem solving are processes that occur throughout everyday life, although their quality can vary depending on the information available, circumstances and how alternatives are considered. This reflection examines one important decision and one significant problem from my experiences. The first concerns my decision to leave university and later return to complete my psychology degree. The second concerns an incident in my role as a residential childcare practitioner in which a young person locked themselves in their bedroom and prevented staff from completing welfare checks. I first describe how I approached each situation at the time, without applying knowledge gained from the module, before considering how I would approach them differently using critical-thinking, decision-making and problem-solving principles. Halpern and Dunn (2023) describe critical thinking as purposeful, reasoned thinking directed towards achieving particular goals.

## **Decision: Leaving and Returning to University**

### **My original approach**

An important decision I made was to leave university after a period in which I felt unable to continue with my studies. I had already started my psychology degree but was struggling to maintain the commitment required. I felt I needed a break and believed stepping away would give me an opportunity to reassess what I wanted.

My decision was largely based on how I felt at the time. I considered the immediate pressure more strongly than the potential long-term consequences of leaving. I thought taking time away would allow me to work, gain experience and become clearer about my future. I did not formally list alternatives or systematically compare leaving with continuing. Instead, I talked to people close to me, thought about the situation and eventually decided that leaving was the best option.

After approximately two years away, I began to reconsider. My experiences in employment and increasing interest in working with children made me think more seriously about my long-term career. I realised psychology remained important to the future I wanted. Returning therefore became a possibility. I considered how it would affect my work and personal life and decided completing the degree was worth the difficulties involved.

### **How I would approach the decision now**

With the knowledge gained from this module, I would approach the decision more deliberately. Halpern and Dunn (2023) identify decision making as an area in which critical-thinking skills can be applied. Rather than asking simply, “Should I leave university?”, I would define the question as “What option is most likely to support my academic, financial, personal and long-term career goals?”

I would identify realistic alternatives, including continuing, reducing my workload if possible, taking an authorised interruption, changing my study arrangements, or leaving temporarily with a specific plan for returning. For each, I would consider advantages, disadvantages, short and long-term consequences. This would make the opportunity costs clearer. For example, leaving could reduce immediate pressure but delay graduation and make returning more difficult.

I would also consider uncertainty. Tversky and Kahneman (1974) demonstrated that people can rely on heuristics when making judgements under uncertainty, potentially producing systematic errors. In my original decision, the immediate difficulty of university was highly noticeable, whereas the benefits of completing the degree were more distant. I would therefore ask whether the most emotionally salient factor was receiving too much weight simply because it was immediate.

I would use a “consider-the-opposite” approach by asking what evidence supported the alternative conclusion. If I believed leaving was necessary, I would ask what evidence suggested I could continue with appropriate changes. If I believed I should stay, I would ask what evidence suggested continuing was unsustainable. This would challenge assumptions rather than encourage confirmation of my initial view.

Finally, I would establish a review point. If leaving remained the best option, I would create a concrete plan for what I would do during the break, what I hoped to achieve and when I would reassess returning. This would make the decision more purposeful.

### **Reflection on the two approaches**

The main difference is that my original decision was predominantly intuitive and focused on immediate circumstances, whereas the revised approach would be structured, evidence based and concerned with consequences. My original approach was not necessarily irrational: taking a break ultimately gave me time to reconsider my goals and contributed to my decision to return. However, I did not have a systematic process for evaluating alternatives.

The module-informed approach may therefore have helped me reach a better decision initially or at least make the consequences of each option clearer. Critical thinking would not necessarily have resulted in me staying at university. Instead, it could have helped me determine whether leaving was genuinely the best option rather than simply the option providing the greatest immediate relief. Effective decision making is therefore about improving the reasoning process rather than guaranteeing a particular outcome (Halpern & Dunn, 2023).

### **Problem: A Young Person Preventing Welfare Checks**

#### **My original approach**

A significant problem I encountered in residential childcare involved a young person locking themselves inside their bedroom and preventing staff from completing welfare checks. This created a conflict between respecting the young person's privacy and ensuring they were safe. Staff could not assume the young person was safe because they were refusing contact, but repeatedly attempting to gain access could also increase distress or confrontation.

At the time, I remained calm and focused on communication. I recognised that becoming confrontational could make the situation worse, so I attempted to understand why the young person did not want staff to enter. I also worked within the expectations of the home, involving other staff and communicating the situation

appropriately. The priority was to establish whether there was an immediate concern for the young person's safety and respond according to the circumstances rather than making assumptions.

The situation was managed through communication, monitoring and staff involvement. Looking back, the problem was not simply that the young person had locked the door. It involved balancing their autonomy and emotional needs with staff responsibility for safeguarding.

### **How I would approach the problem now**

With the knowledge gained from this module, I would approach the problem using a more explicit process. Bransford and Stein's (1993) IDEAL model provides a framework involving identifying the problem, defining goals, exploring strategies, anticipating outcomes, acting, and looking back and learning.

First, I would identify the problem precisely. Rather than defining it as “the young person will not allow a welfare check”, I would recognise the interconnected issues: establishing immediate safety, refusal of access, possible communication difficulties and the need for proportionate intervention.

Second, I would define the goal. The primary goal would be to establish that the young person was safe while minimising unnecessary distress and preserving the relationship between the young person and staff. This is more useful than treating entry to the bedroom as the only measure of success.

Third, I would explore possible strategies. These could include speaking calmly through the door, asking what would help the young person communicate, offering time and space where appropriate, involving a trusted staff member, checking relevant information about their presentation and recent behaviour, and escalating if indicators suggested increased risk. Options would need to be considered alongside safeguarding procedures and the young person's individual risk assessment.

I would then anticipate outcomes before acting. Repeatedly demanding that the door be opened could increase anxiety, reduce cooperation and damage trust, whereas calm communication could encourage voluntary engagement. However, giving excessive space could be inappropriate if there were credible indicators of

immediate danger. The response would therefore depend on the available evidence rather than assuming intervention or non-intervention was automatically correct.

Finally, I would look back and learn. Once the situation had been resolved, I would consider what information was available, which actions helped and whether the young person's care or risk-management arrangements needed review. Bransford and Stein (1993) emphasise this reflective stage as part of the problem-solving cycle.

### **Reflection on the two approaches**

The main difference is that my original response was practical and situation-led, whereas the revised approach would make the problem-solving process explicit. I was already attempting to remain calm, communicate and involve colleagues, but I did not consciously break the situation into a defined problem, goal, alternatives, anticipated consequences and review.

The module-informed approach would probably improve my reasoning because it would prevent me from defining success too narrowly. It would also encourage me to distinguish between observable behaviour and the underlying problem. The young person locking the door was the immediate difficulty, but the wider problem involved safety, autonomy, communication and relationships.

However, structured problem solving does not mean ignoring professional judgement. Residential childcare situations can change quickly, and decisions must remain proportionate to the evidence and safeguarding requirements. Critical thinking should support rather than replace professional procedures and collaboration. The value of the module-informed approach is that it provides a clearer structure while allowing adaptation to changing circumstances.

### **Conclusion**

These experiences demonstrate a difference between how I naturally approached decisions and problems and how I could approach them using critical-thinking knowledge. When deciding whether to leave and later return to university, I relied heavily on immediate experience and personal judgement. I would now systematically identify alternatives, evaluate consequences, challenge assumptions

and account for uncertainty. In the residential childcare situation, I responded practically and attempted to communicate effectively, but the IDEAL model provides a clearer structure for identifying the problem, defining the goal, exploring strategies, anticipating consequences and learning from the outcome.

The module has changed my understanding of effective reasoning. Critical thinking does not mean removing emotion or intuition, nor does it guarantee a particular outcome. Instead, it provides methods for questioning assumptions, considering alternatives and evaluating consequences. Both scenarios suggest that a module-informed approach could have produced more deliberate reasoning and potentially better decisions and solutions while remaining responsive to the circumstances. This is particularly important because both situations involved uncertainty, meaning that good reasoning required flexibility as well as structure, rather than following a fixed procedure without considering changing circumstances carefully.

## References

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